FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

BEST COLLEGES OF INDIA 2025

The India Today Group's annual Best Colleges Survey is much more than a ranking game. In its 29th edition this year, its highly refined comparative method makes it the gold standard for the Indian college aspirant. Wherever you are in the country, you get the most comprehensive mapping of the best options across 14 streams: Arts, Science, Commerce, Engineering, Medicine, Dentistry, Law, BBA, BCA, Hotel Management, Fashion Design and Architecture at the undergraduate level; Mass Communication and Social Work for Master's. The number of participating colleges has nearly doubled from 988 in 2018 to 1,865 now. Our research partner MDRA's rigorous methodology helps sift through entries based on five parameters: 'Intake Quality & Governance', 'Academic Excellence', 'Infrastructure & Living Experience', 'Personality & Leadership Development' and 'Career Progression & Placement'.

It's the continual innovations on a solid base that provide the greatest interest. Over the years, it has become evident that legacy institutions tend to dominate the top slots across disciplines. One more iteration of relatively static rankings, we feel, is not particularly insightful. Focusing on a few elite institutions also takes your eyes away from the real and meaningful action unfolding away from the centre. We have consistently sought to breach that opacity. In 2023, we introduced a new category: Best Colleges in 12 Individual Subjects. That enabled students to get less distracted by institutional prestige and focus more on genuine outcomes—the best faculties for any given subject may not always be in the most prestigious colleges.



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This year, we bring you an exciting new feature, the Most Improved Colleges. Across all 14 streams, we spotlight one college in each stream that has shown the greatest percentage improvement in rankings over the past five years. While they may lag behind in the social and cultural capital accumulated by elite institutions, this category acknowledges their dogged pursuit of quality. This helps broaden and deepen the scope of our survey, enriching its search for the best options in a wide variety of contexts.

A few examples will suffice to demonstrate the insights we gain here. The hallowed All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS) in Delhi, unsurprisingly, continues to be No. 1 in its fiercely competitive stream. But AIIMS Jodhpur is the one institution that has made the highest percentage leap in the past five years, from No. 25 in 2020 to No. 10 now. Even in the past year, it has jumped four places. Similarly, Maharaja Agrasen Institute of Technology, Delhi, has jumped from Rank 41 to 14 among private engineering colleges. For BBA, Galgotias University's School of Business, Greater Noida, has leapfrogged from No. 82 in 2020 to No. 35 today. We consistently see such great movement in the ranges below the top echelons. By taking a five-year benchmark, we look for consistency in this striving for excellence and arrive at the one to spotlight. That's how we capture the great changes sweeping over higher education, as access to quality slowly gets democratised in India.

This level of analysis is built on top of the valuable distinctions from our previous editions. Our rankings already go beyond metros to showcase promising institutions in Tier 2 and 3 cities, many of which have climbed into the Top 30. As before, we list the top three colleges in several smaller cities. Also, the colleges that offer the best return on investment when you weigh career outcomes against the fees. What we have for you is thus not frozen frames of peaks that may be too distant. Rather, it's an inclusive and enabling tool that meets real needs. For college aspirants, we cut through the clutter and point to new hunting grounds. For employers, this opens up new recruitment pools of raw, trainable talent. Our interactive website—bestcolleges.indiatoday.in—takes this a step forward. A live information hub, it hosts eight years of our polling data that tracks as many as 2,750 colleges across 14 streams.

This user-friendly database also answers to a larger objective. Everyone knows how urgent it is for India to ramp up its higher education, in quality and depth, as well as spread and equal access. About half of our mammoth population is under 25 years of age—the world's largest youth cohort. About 10 per cent are in the vitally formative 18-23 age-group. India's higher education system, as it grows rapidly, is trying to close a severe demand-supply mismatch. Out of 150 million or so young Indians of college-going age, we have a gross enrolment ratio of only 28.4 per cent. That's an improvement over the 23.7 per cent recorded in 2014-15. But clearly, what's touted as "the world's second largest higher education system", with 58,000-plus institutions at last count, is nowhere near enough in terms of capacity. Our Best Colleges Survey is thus a higher education atlas for our times, capturing a dynamically evolving sector in a way that's alive to India's real challenge, the horizontal spread of quality education. Think of this as a Sit-Rep for 2025 on the human infrastructure that will build India's future.

This special issue is our offering to India's demographic dividend. Invest well, and all the best for your future!

(Aroon Purie)

For an 8-year comparative analysis, go to **https://bestcolleges.indiatoday.in**